

INTRODUCTION

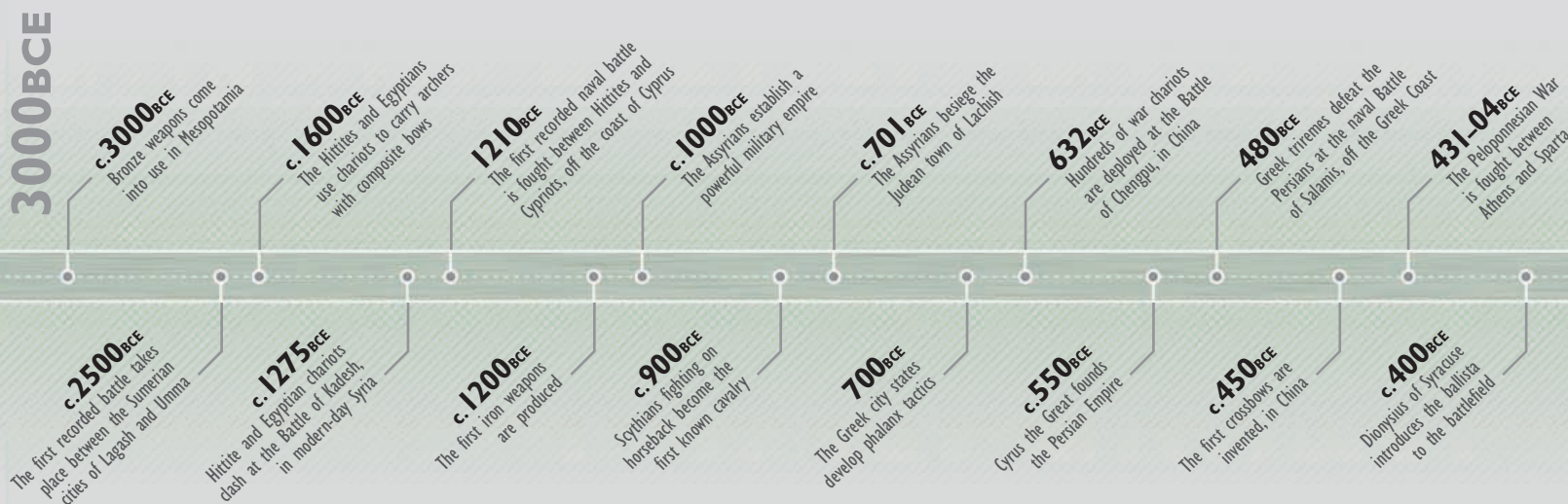
Early humans developed weapons of wood and stone, such as clubs, axes, spears, and simple bows, for hunting and fighting; the growth of civilizations from around 3000BCE onwards led to advances in both technology and organization.

The first military developments were slow, emerging over centuries, or even millennia. Stone weapons were gradually replaced by those of more effective materials – first copper and bronze, then iron and steel; meanwhile, missile weapons increased in range and penetrative power with the advent of the composite bow, and later, the crossbow. The invention of wheeled vehicles and the domestication of horses gave rise to the war chariot, which dominated battlefields from Egypt to China until, imitating the mounted warriors of central Asia, settled civilizations learned to fight on horseback. The building of fortifications led to the new art of siege warfare, and conflict also took to the sea, with oared war galleys operating in the Mediterranean by the 8th century BCE.

In ancient warfare, fighting methods and organization were generally more important to success than technological superiority. The Assyrians conquered an empire with the world's first permanent professional army, in the 1st millennium BCE, and the Romans ruled the most famous of ancient empires with an army of professional legionaries who also excelled as military engineers, building roads, bridges, forts, and frontier fortifications. The Greeks, meanwhile, won renown for their tactical skills – whether as infantry in their tightknit phalanx formations, or at sea, manoeuvring their lightweight galleys, the triremes.

None of the settled civilizations, however, were safe against the nomadic peoples – or “barbarians” as they were known – outside their borders. The “civilized” technological advantages of torsion catapults and crossbows counted for little against bands of mounted warriors, who were highly skilled in raid and ambush. East and West Asia, India, and Europe all faced severe problems from incursions by central Asian nomadic horsemen.

KEY DATES



KING TUTANKHAMEN – c.1300BCE



THE MAHABHARATAS WAR – c.1300BCE



THE SIEGE OF LACHISH – 701BCE

